

Q What is the reaction of customers and partners about your use of open source technology? Does the dearth of talent not affect your business?

Well, there's no denying that hiring and maintaining talent with good exposure to open source technology is difficult.

But having said that, we at Naukri, allow our developers to be as experimental and creative as possible. Hiring is definitely a challenge because the kind of expertise we want people to have is not available. But I think the situation is changing considerably today. People now know how the Linux operating system works, but

its administration and management is still difficult. There is still a shortage of professionals on the expertise front. For example, a lot of professionals don't know about the simplest things in Linux virtual environments. So, what I understand is that people are aware of open source technology nowadays, but there is a lack of in-depth knowledge about the subject matter. They know how Linux works, they know about basic commands but there is no in-depth knowledge.

Q Do you feel the need to connect with the community and discuss the technical issues?

Yes, we are engaged with the people developing the platforms that we work on. I have participated in the open source event organised by EFY as well, to interact with the community. MySQL is one of our most prominent tools. We have interacted with the community around MySQL whenever we got stuck. In fact, that is the way to go about things in the world of open source technology. This is the biggest advantage of using it. One can always go back to the community for any help. But in our case, we have not seen that need arising often.

Q Do you or any of your team mates interact with the open source community now?

Not as much.

Q Why not?

As mentioned earlier, we already face a dearth of good talent. One prime purpose of choosing open source technology is that there is already a lot of work done around each open source project, so one does not need to invest that much in technology. Organisations that do interact with the community have enough of talent. Second, I think there is also a cultural aspect to this. We want to pay back and contribute to the open source community. We will do that sometime in the future but as of now, we do not have enough resources to do so. Also, earlier there was a challenge. The software was built in a way that a lot of IP was tied into the code. So we

had to detach them. Besides, if you have to open source a piece of software, the quality of code should be very good and it should not break under any circumstances. We have been wanting to contribute for a long time but ultimately, as an organisation, it is difficult to make

contributions. It is usually individuals who make contributions. So, we can only evangelise and recommend that our employees contribute to projects. What usually happens is that either people are low on bandwidth to do that or their applications' designs do not permit them to take out a piece of code and give it away to the community. But we are trying to move people in that direction now.

Q What are the major challenges you face while doing business with open source technology?

The first major road block is the unavailability of talent. Second is the learning curve within the country. People get coaching and training on proprietary software easily but when it comes to open source technology, the scene is exactly the opposite. Third, finding support for newer platforms is slightly different. There are no SLAs, so you have to find your own way. There is always a risk added to it. Sometimes you may find answers to your problems and sometimes you may not. The benefit is that you always have the option of delving deep into the source code to find out the root cause of the problem.

Q As I see it, there is good demand for open source talent in India but the supply is not adequate. What do you believe are the reasons for this?

The first and foremost reason is slower pace of adoption of open source technology. A lot of companies still don't want to adopt open source technology. A lot of institutes don't care to teach open source technology. If we look at the education given in colleges, it is very different from how industry works and wants students to be. If you look at the engineering colleges, not all have open source technology as a part of their curriculum.

Q So even with freshers, do you look only at south India or do you explore colleges from the north as well?

While hiring freshers, we don't have to look for any particular skill set except their basic knowledge. So, we don't mind exploring north Indian colleges as well. We hire freshers and then train them.

Q What kind of training do you provide?

We have an induction capsule comprising four-five platforms around which we teach and conduct courses for a month and try to get people accustomed to the technologies that we use. 

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—Vibhore Sharma, CTO, Naukri.com